

Beyond Boundaries — what do the Xenium multimodal segmentation stains add to the transcriptome?

Data. Mouse EAE spinal cord (RRMAP2 runs 5 and 6): 18 annotated Xenium 5K sections, 25 animals (chronic and relapse-remitting EAE, CFA controls), 500,379 annotated cells. Four morphology channels besides transcripts: DAPI · ATP1A1/CD45/E-Cadherin (boundary) · 18S rRNA (interior RNA) · αSMA/Vimentin (interior protein).

Approach. Per cell and channel: intensities in 6 compartments (nucleus, cytoplasm, 1 μm rim, 2 μm ring, 10 μm territory), radial profile, polarity, texture, morphology (201 features; notebook 01) → background / normalisation (02) → do the stains show known biology (03) → how much of each image feature does the transcriptome explain, and vice versa (04) → is the rest technical or biological; does it add per animal (05) → targeted readouts (06) → look at the cells (07).

This notebook only *collects* results (figures from [results/](#) , tables from CSVs); every number links to the notebook that computed it.

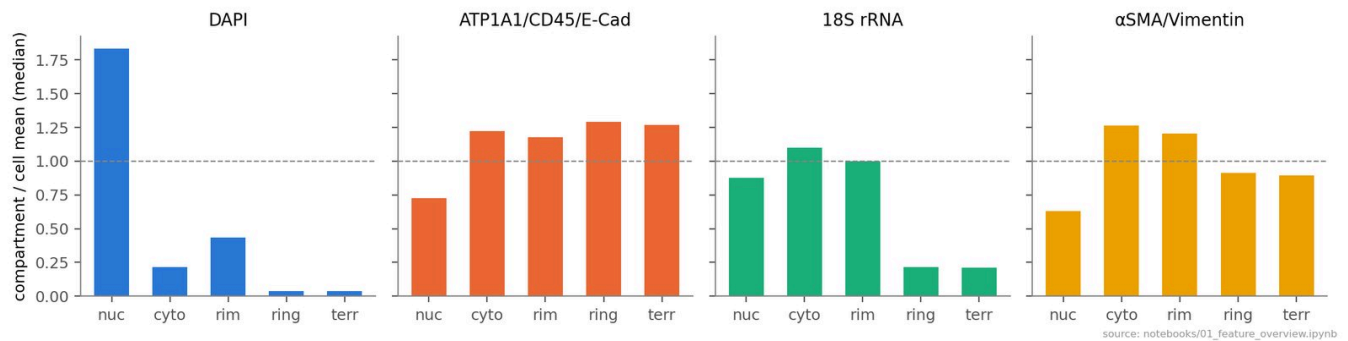
Bottom line

question	answer	where
Do the stains show known biology?	Yes — VSMC αSMA, leukocyte & ependymal vimentin, neuron 18S, low ch3 in neurons/oligos; all 25 animals	03
Is CD45 usable?	No — boundary channel behaves as ATP1A1 (neuropil) only, even in low-neuropil areas	03
How much of the image does the transcriptome explain?	~15 % per feature (median); morphology and rim/cyto intensities best	04
Is the unexplained ~85 % hidden biology?	Mostly not — a local optical/staining field shared across cell types + cell-level variation unrelated to lesions	05
Do images add to the transcriptome for lesion identity?	No ($\leq +0.015$ AUROC; niches are transcriptome-defined)	04
...for clinical score per animal?	Images alone $p = 0.46$ ($p = 0.04$) vs transcriptome 0.86; combined not better	05
What <i>do</i> they add?	Measurements of genes not on the panel (<i>Vim</i> , <i>Acta2</i> , <i>Atp1a1</i>): vimentin reactivity timing, WM neuropil loss (–25 %) , 18S gain in activated lesion cells , T-cell 18S polarity towards vessels, a	05–07

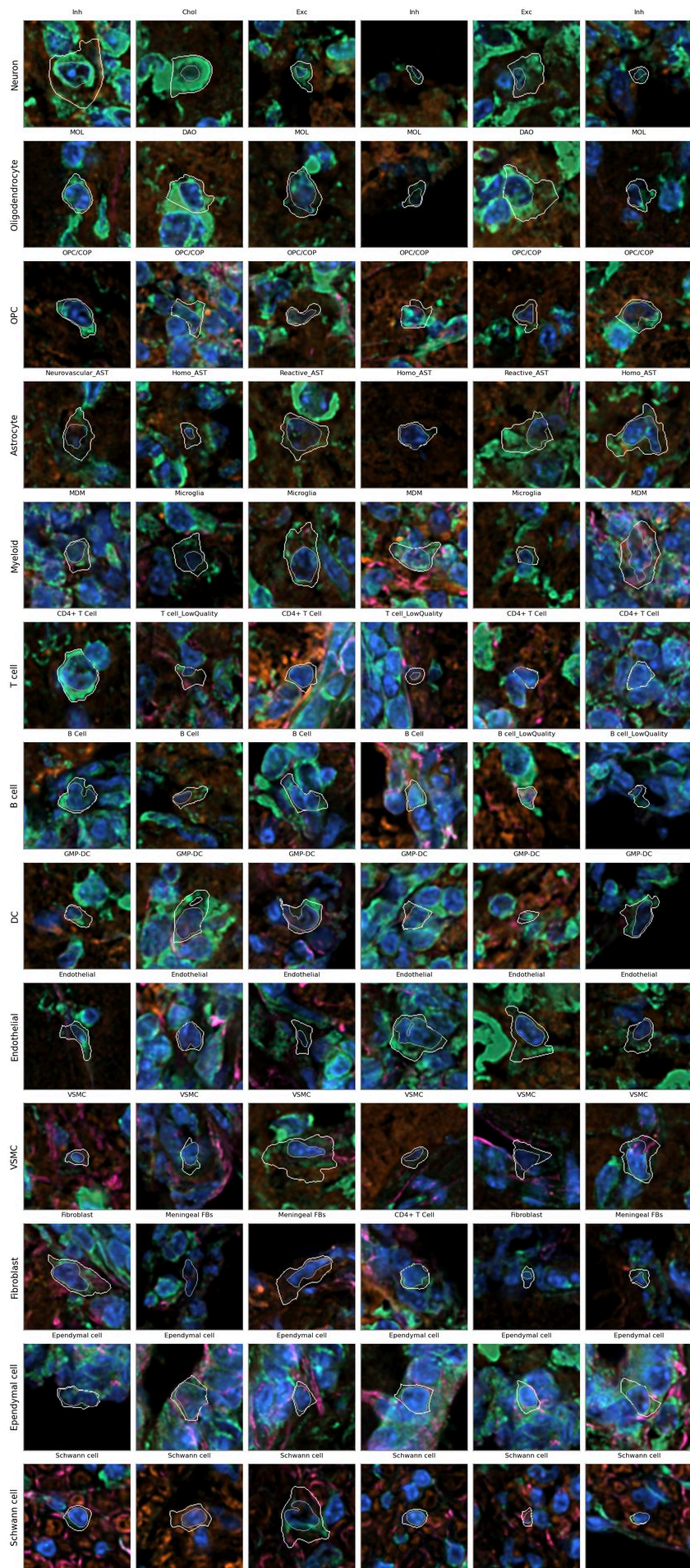
candidate **18S-texture severity marker** (holds within section and after a crowding adjustment)

1. Features look right (notebook 01)

Mask areas equal Xenium's exactly; centroids within 0.28 μm ; 0 truncated cells. Each stain has its own compartment — notably **ATP1A1 is higher *outside* cells** (neuropil).



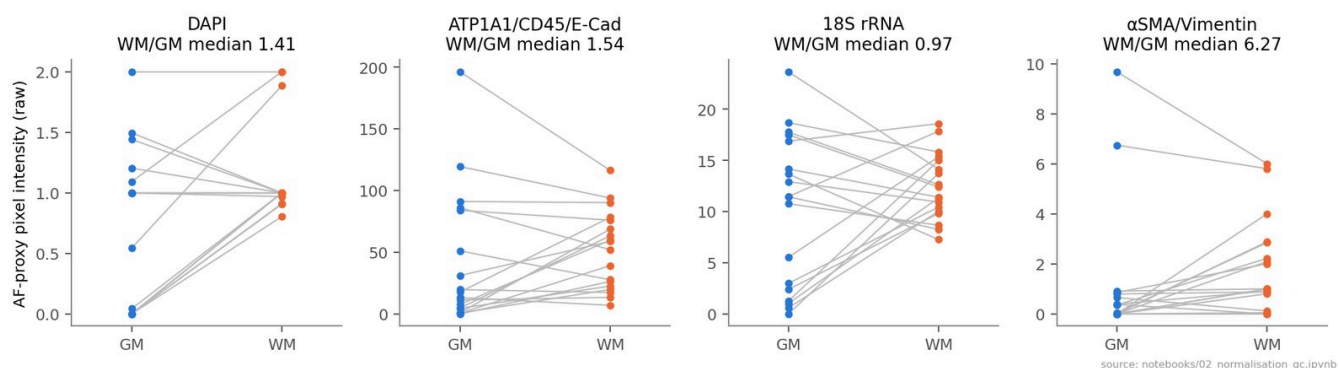
results/01_features/compartment_profile.png



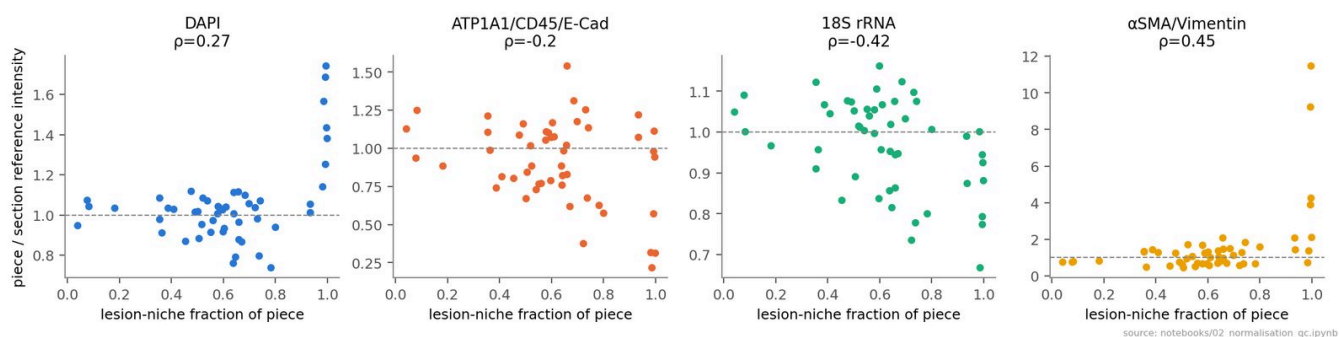
2. Background and normalisation (notebook 02)

No broadband myelin autofluorescence (18S WM/GM 0.97). Final normalisation = local background subtraction, scaled per section by the p90 of physiological-niche cells. **Stain intensity tracks**

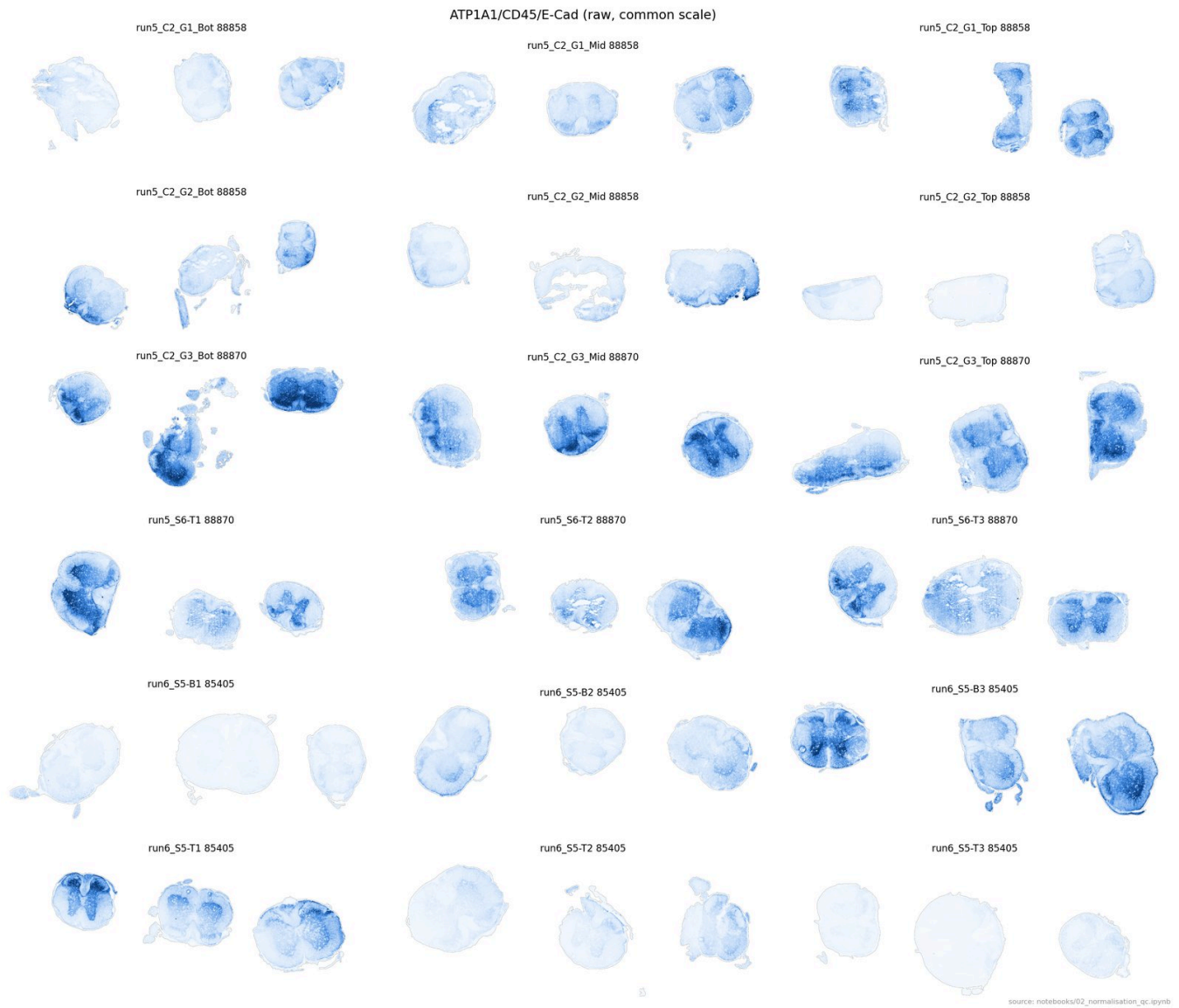
disease at piece level: α SMA/Vim brighter ($\rho = 0.45$, $p = 8e-4$) and 18S dimmer ($\rho = -0.42$, $p = 0.002$) in physiological-niche cells of sicker animals.



results/02_normalisation_qc/af_wm_vs_gm.png



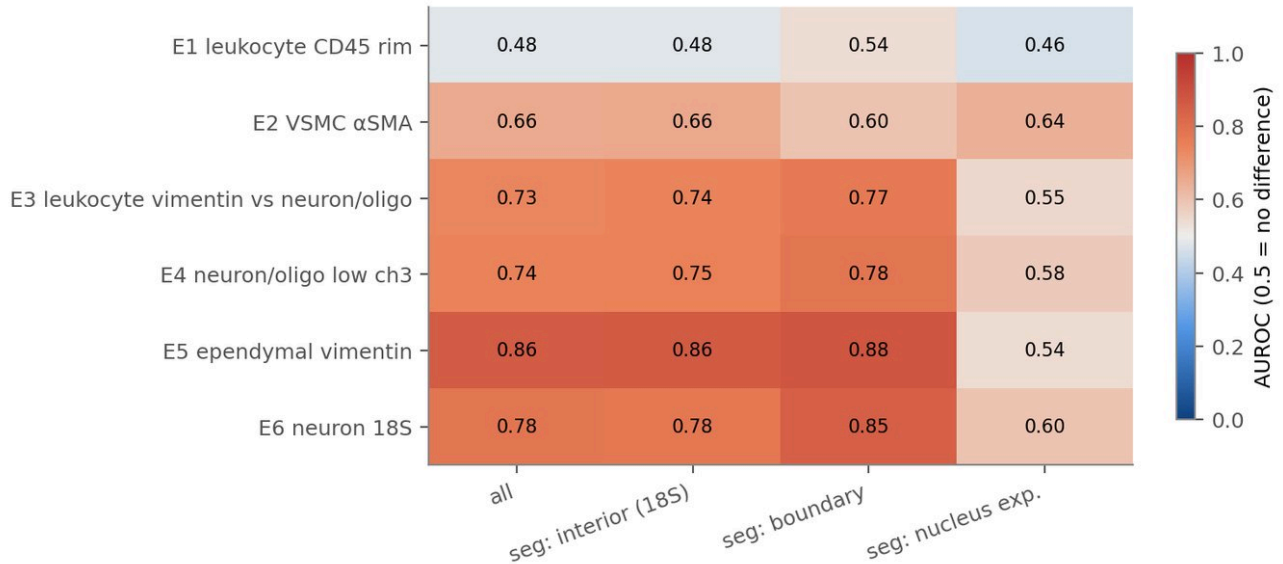
results/02_normalisation_qc/piece_intensity_vs_lesion.png



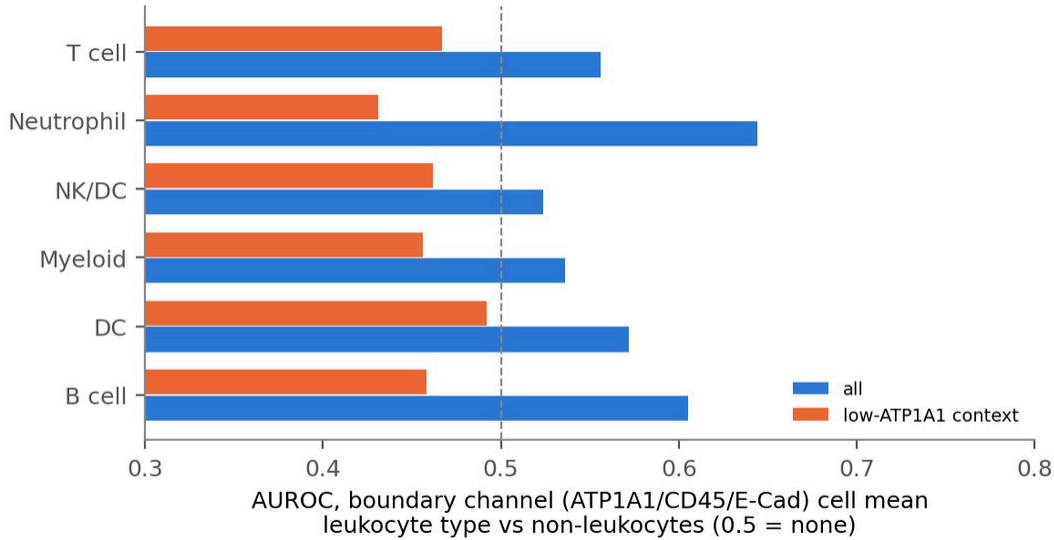
results/02_normalisation_qc/spatial_bnd.png

3. The stains recover known biology — except CD45 (notebook 03)

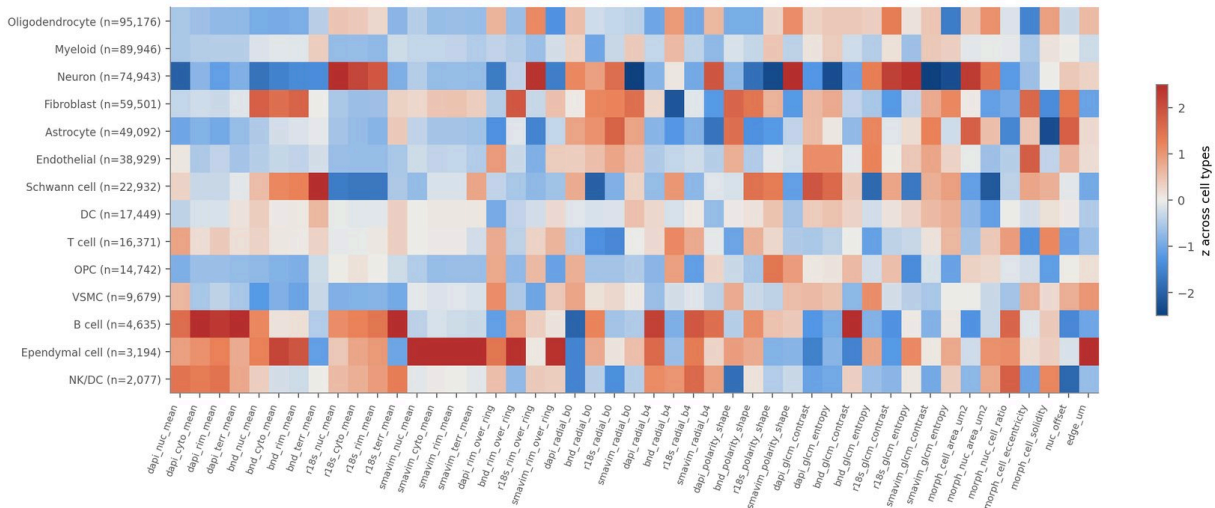
	test	feature	auroc	verdict
0	E1 leukocyte CD45 rim	bnd_rim_over_ring	0.477	fails
5	E2 VSMC α SMA	smavim_cell_mean	0.656	holds
10	E3 leukocyte vimentin vs neuron/oligo	smavim_cell_mean	0.734	holds
15	E4 neuron/oligo low ch3	smavim_cell_mean	0.743	holds
20	E5 ependymal vimentin	smavim_cell_mean	0.859	holds
25	E6 neuron 18S	r18s_cyto_mean	0.780	holds



results/03_sanatlas/expectation_tests.png

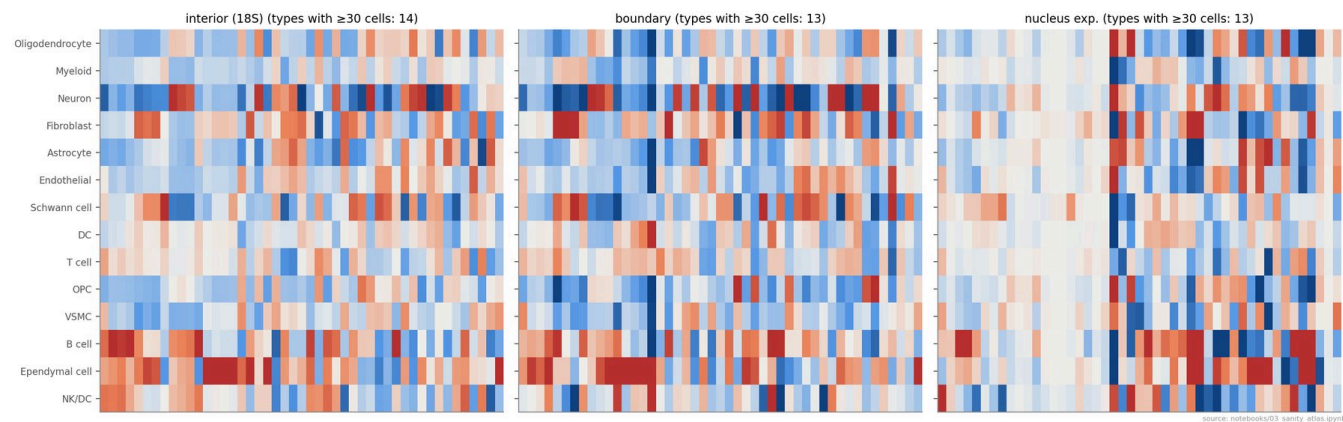


results/03_sanatlas/E1_cd45_context.png



results/03_sanity_atlas/atlas_celltype_heatmap.png

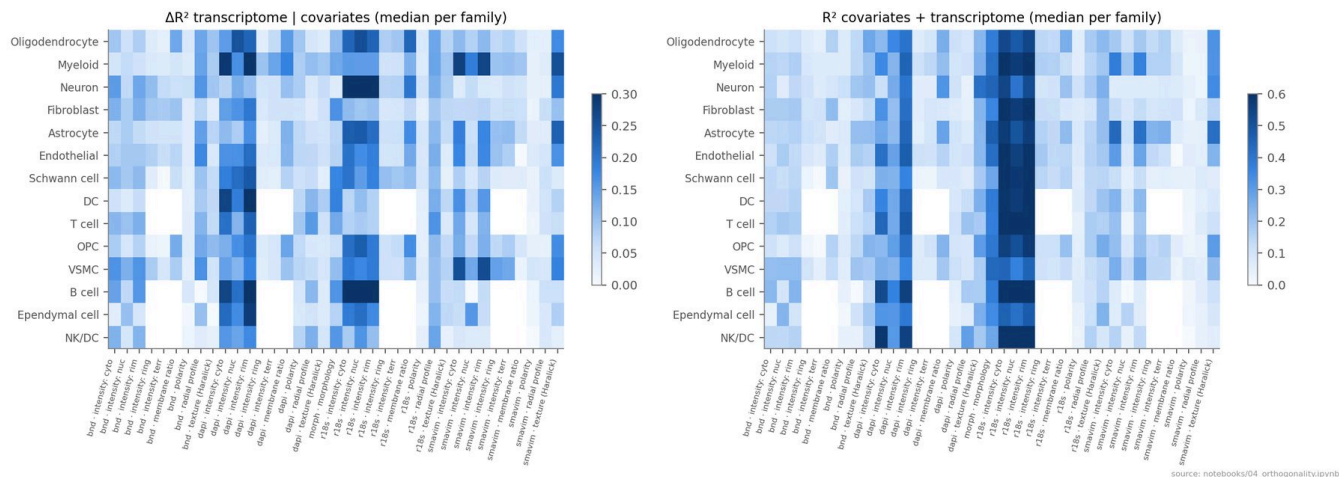
Segmentation method shifts shape/distribution features for every cell type (the stain drew that edge), so all downstream analyses use 18S-segmented cells (96 %).



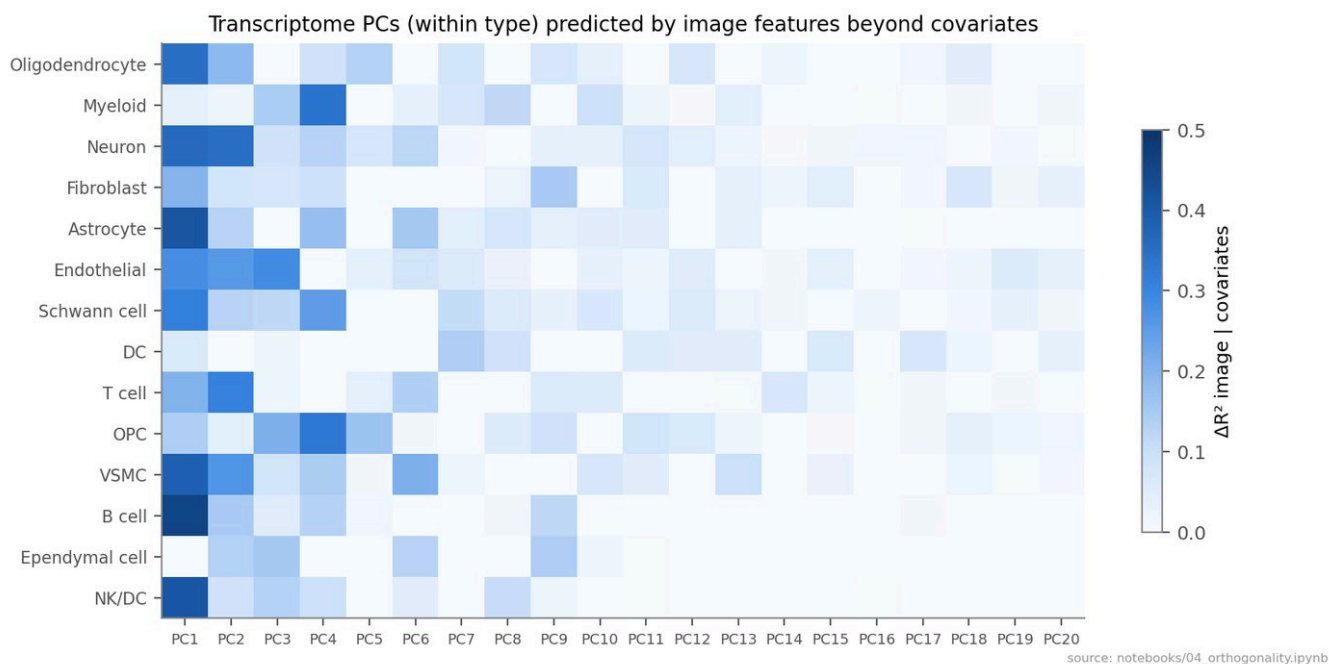
results/03_sanity_atlas/atlas_by_segmethod.png

4. The transcriptome explains ~15 % of the image; images predict transcriptional state (notebook 04)

	R ² covariates	R ² covariates + transcriptome	Δ R ² transcriptome
cell_type			
Schwann cell	0.029	0.112	0.068
Fibroblast	0.042	0.123	0.068
Neuron	0.035	0.127	0.072
Ependymal cell	0.019	0.130	0.064
NK/DC	0.068	0.142	0.056
VSMC	0.037	0.148	0.091
B cell	0.053	0.148	0.067
Oligodendrocyte	0.048	0.152	0.090
Endothelial	0.063	0.156	0.075
OPC	0.048	0.160	0.067
Myeloid	0.055	0.163	0.105
DC	0.048	0.165	0.080
T cell	0.052	0.171	0.091
Astrocyte	0.081	0.177	0.071



results/04_orthogonality/r2_heatmaps.png



results/04_orthogonality/reverse_pcs.png

Genes best predicted by the images (beyond covariates), top 6 per cell type — reactive astrocyte genes, neurofilaments, oligodendrocyte maturation genes, and neighbour spill-over genes:

top genes predicted by image

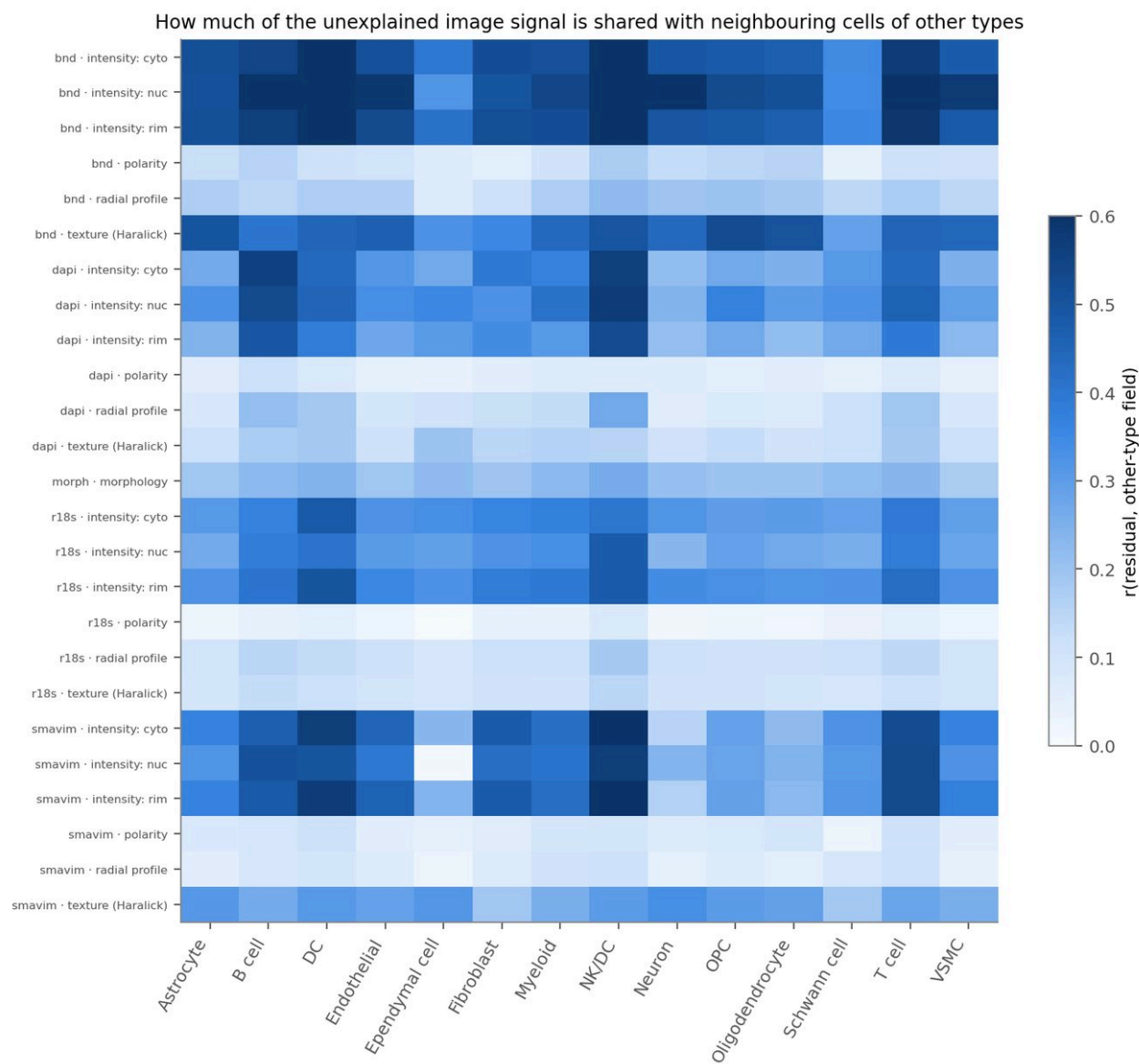
cell_type	
Astrocyte	Slc6a11, C3, Snap25, Fgfr3, A2m, Aldoc
B cell	Jchain, Igkc, Sel1l, Gfap, Tent5c, Mzb1
DC	Mbp, Neat1, Gfap, Snap25, Cst7, Lamp1
Endothelial	Snap25, Eno2, Aldoc, Ckb, Sncb, Map2
Ependymal cell	Mbp, Adamts20, Syne1, Plec, Tll6, Rsph1
Fibroblast	Gfap, Ptgs, Mbp, Neat1, Ctss, Crabp2
Myeloid	Aldoc, Snap25, Map2, Ckb, Nefl, Mbp
NK/DC	Mbp, Gfap, Il2rb, Klrk1, Cd74, H2-D1
Neuron	Meg3, Mbp, Nefm, Nefh, Map1b, Snap25
OPC	Gfap, Snap25, Aldoc, Sncb, Eno2, Glra1
Oligodendrocyte	Snap25, Gfap, Klk6, Eno2, Sncb, Ermn
Schwann cell	Pmp22, Cnp, Mbp, Cryab, Smtn, Cd9
T cell	Mbp, Gfap, H2-D1, C3, Aldoc, Cd74
VSMC	Vtn, Pdgfrb, Snap25, Mbp, Aldoc, Kcnj8

Images are redundant with the transcriptome for lesion-niche identity:

	n	lesion_frac	AUROC tx	AUROC tx+img	AUROC img	Δ AUROC (img tx)
cell_type						
Oligodendrocyte	29895	0.605	0.928	0.929	0.650	0.001
Myeloid	29860	0.942	0.932	0.929	0.670	-0.003
Neuron	29988	0.290	0.846	0.850	0.471	0.004
Fibroblast	29183	0.916	0.884	0.898	0.716	0.015
Astrocyte	29816	0.603	0.947	0.947	0.757	-0.000
Endothelial	27406	0.645	0.937	0.938	0.747	0.001
Schwann cell	20610	0.367	0.936	0.940	0.769	0.004
OPC	14183	0.680	0.955	0.958	0.822	0.003
VSMC	8375	0.791	0.794	0.807	0.650	0.013
Ependymal cell	3005	0.062	0.948	0.946	0.816	-0.002

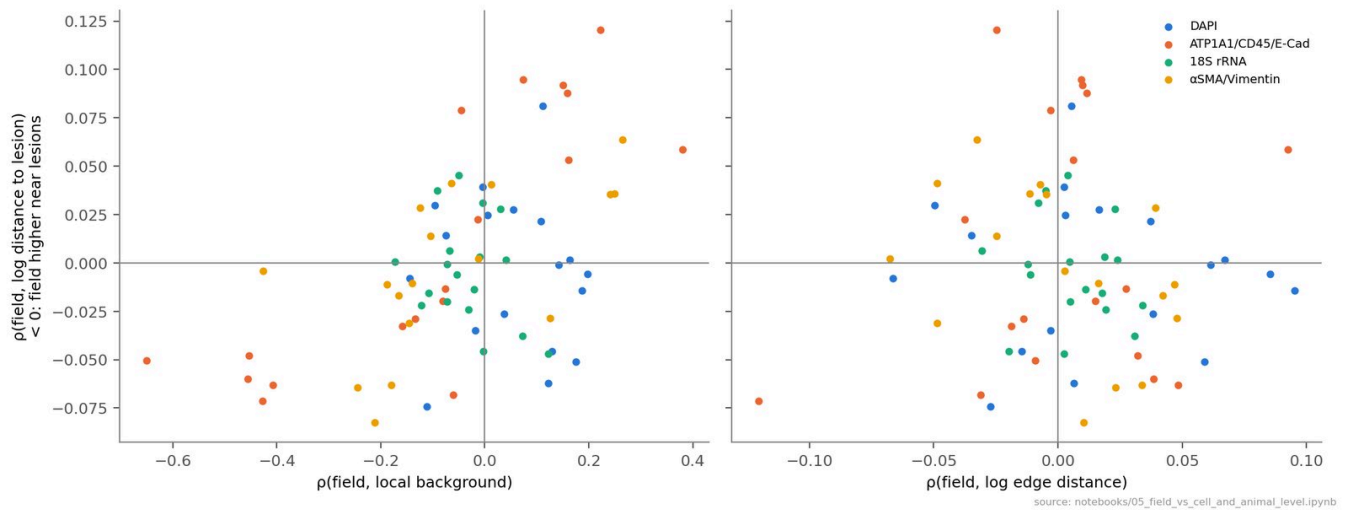
5. What is the unexplained 85 %? (notebook 05)

Much of it is shared with neighbouring cells of *other* types (a local field) and that field does not follow lesions; the cell-specific remainder barely does either.



source: notebooks/05_field_vs_cell_and_animal_level.ipynb

results/05_field_and_animal/field_share_heatmap.png



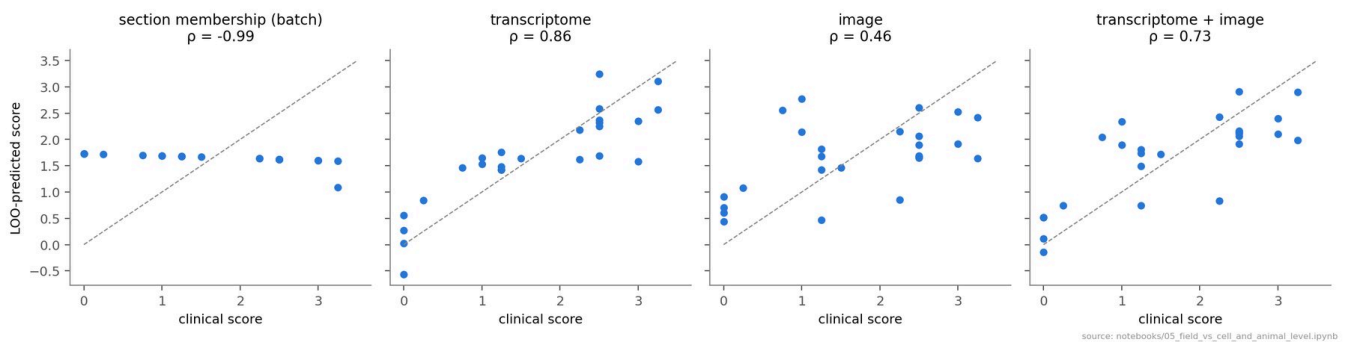
results/05_field_and_animal/field_lesion_vs_technical.png

tests $q < 0.05$

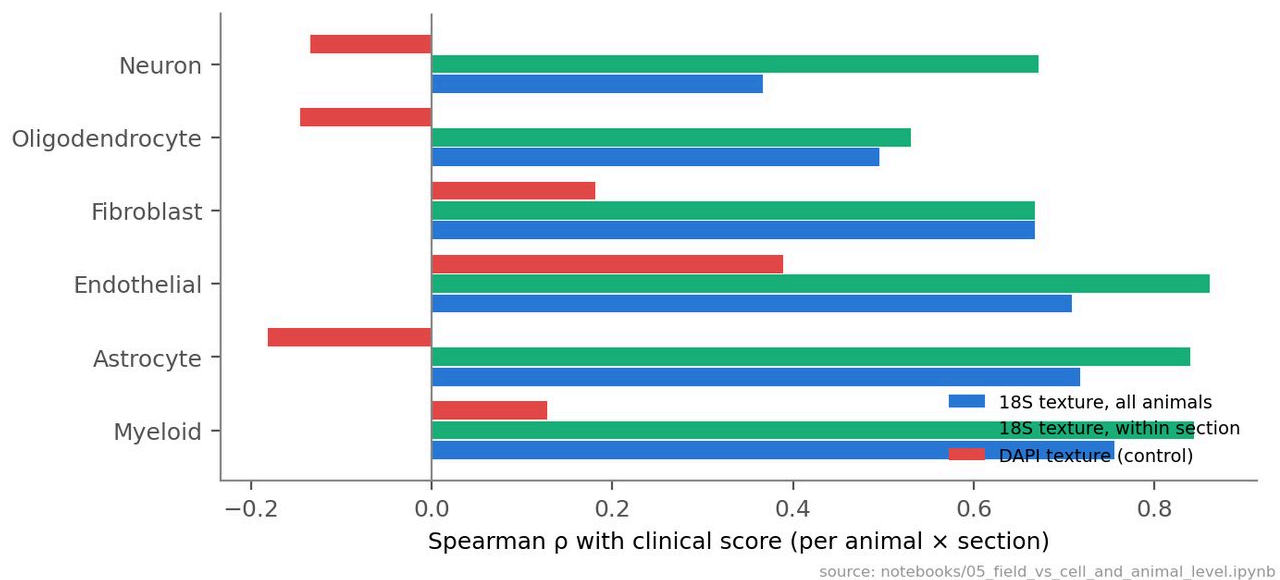
part		
cell-specific	924	19
field	924	21
full residual	924	19

6. Per animal: images carry real but weaker disease information; 18S texture stands out (notebooks 05, 07)

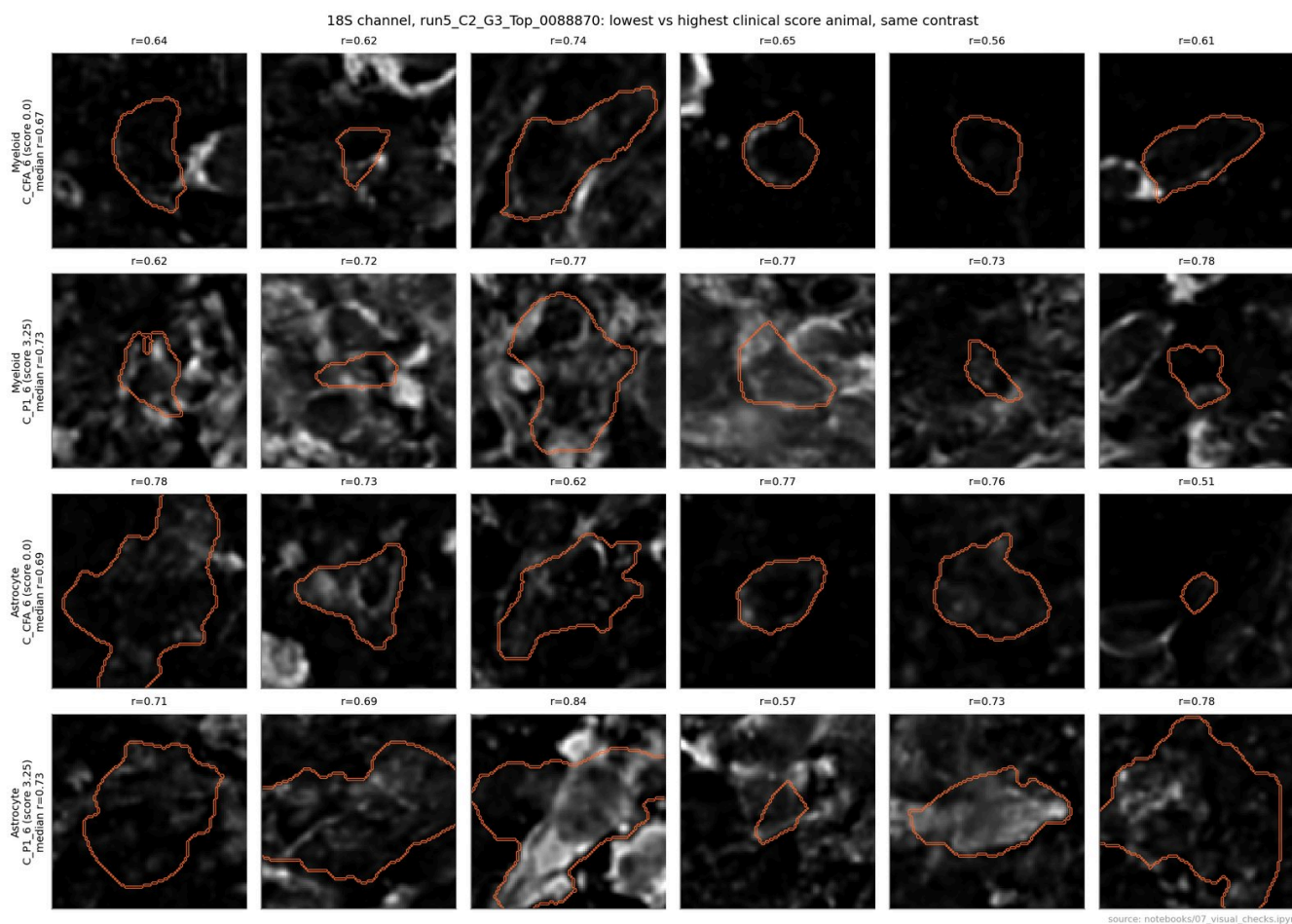
	R^2	Spearman ρ	perm p (ρ)
section membership (batch)	-0.152	-0.990	NaN
transcriptome	0.748	0.859	0.005
image	0.284	0.456	0.040
transcriptome + image	0.586	0.735	NaN



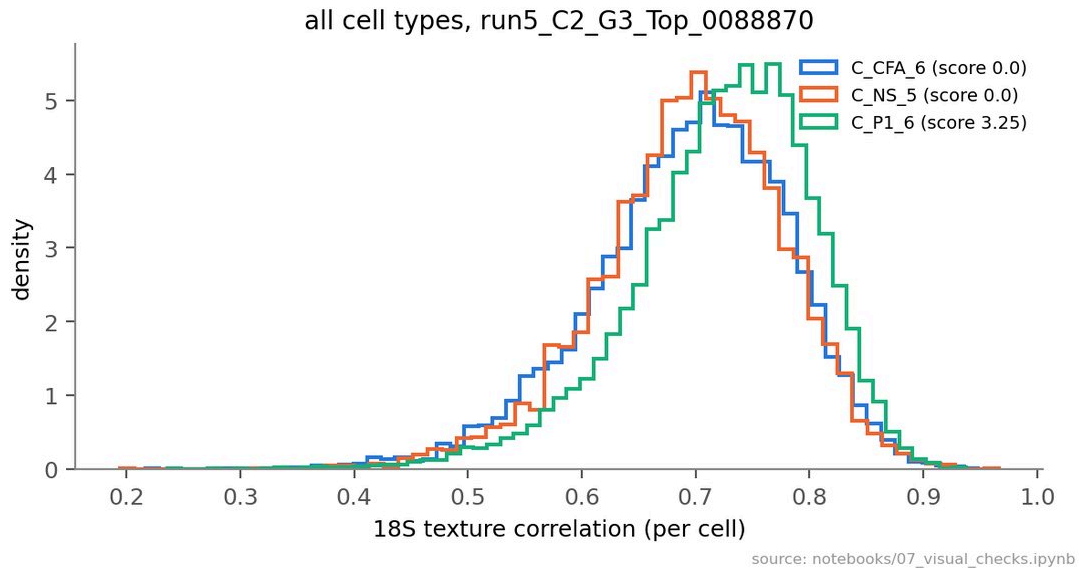
results/05_field_and_animal/animal_score_prediction.png



results/05_field_and_animal/r18s_texture_within_section.png

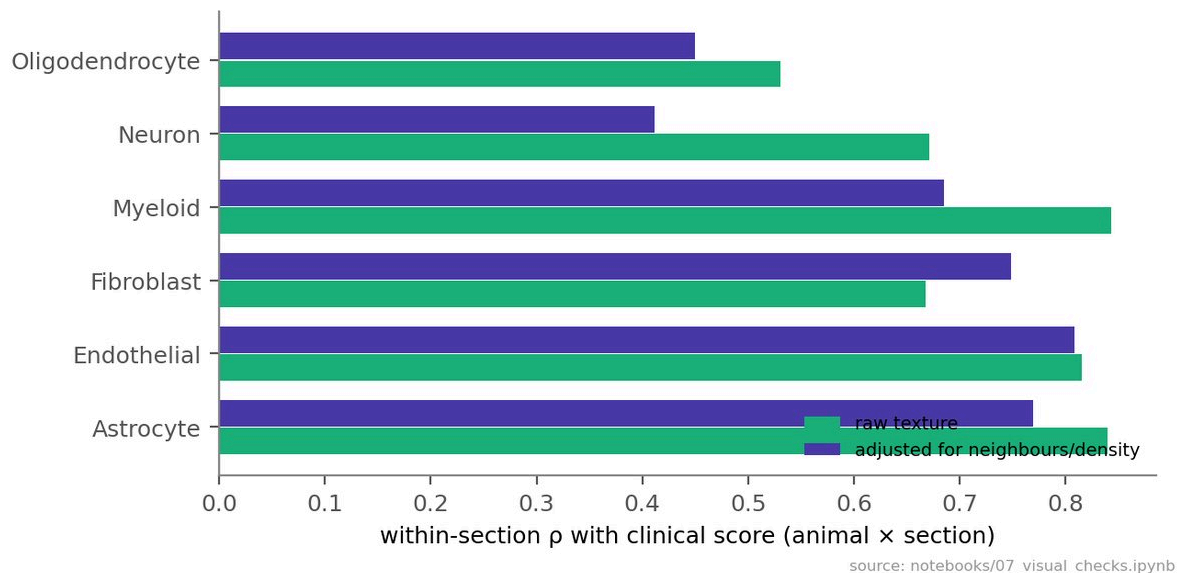


results/07_visual_checks/r18s_texture_low_vs_high_score.png



results/07_visual_checks/r18s_texture_per_animal_hist.png

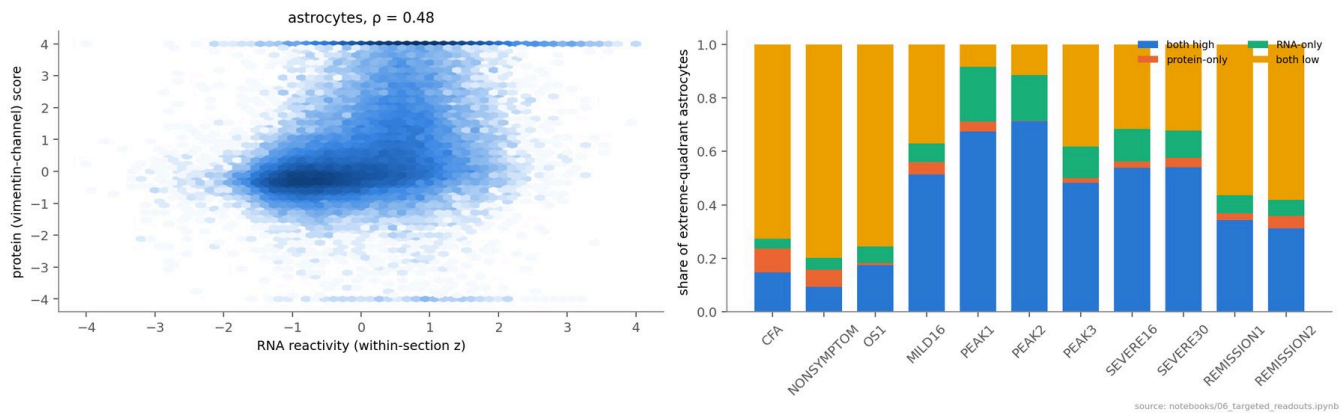
Is it just crowding (bright 18S neighbours bleeding in)? Mostly not — the within-section link survives adjustment for neighbouring 18S, local density and cell size:



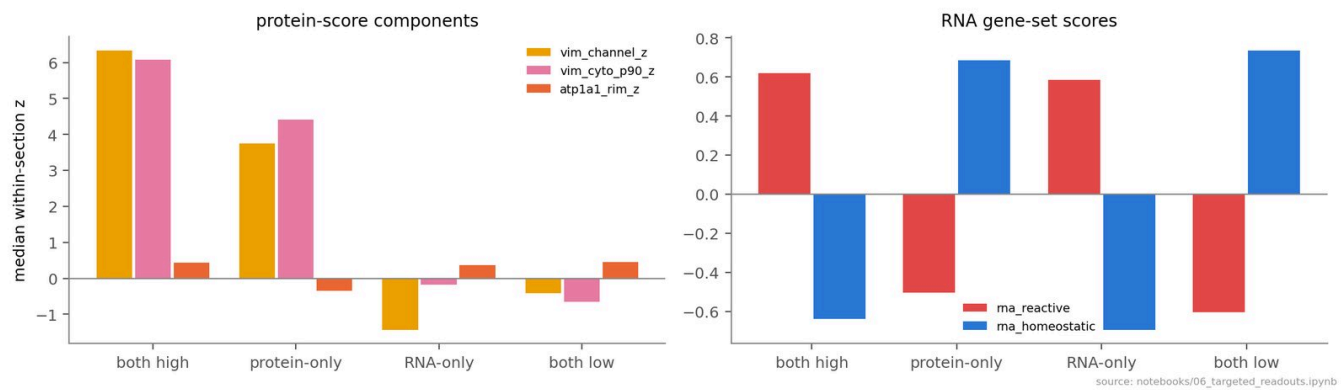
results/07_visual_checks/r18s_texture_crowding_adjustment.png

7. Targeted readouts (notebooks 06, 07)

Astrocyte reactivity: vimentin protein vs RNA — transcription comes first

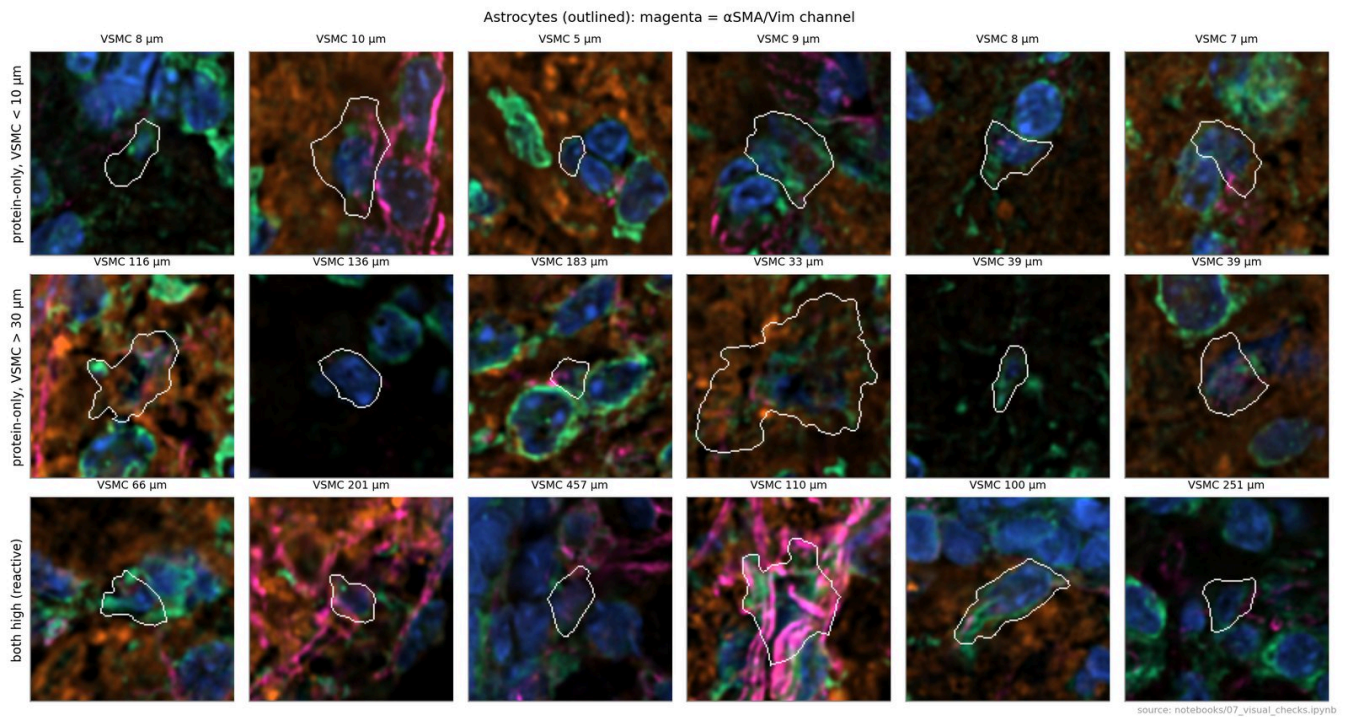


results/06_targeted_readouts/astro_protein_vs_rna.png



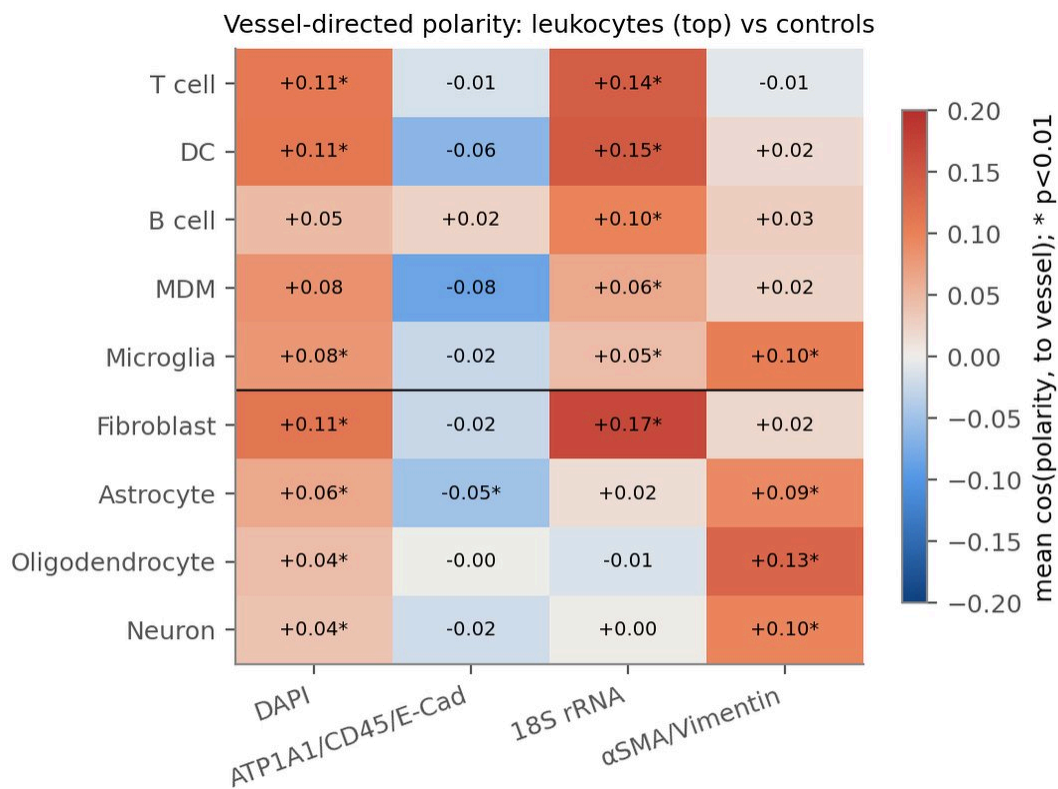
results/06_targeted_readouts/astro_quadrant_components.png

	n	lesion_frac	WM_frac	lesion_dist_median	edge_um_median	area_median	trans
quadrant							
both high	5853	0.950	0.856	0.000	101.389	88.190	
protein-only	401	0.284	0.147	29.779	297.379	74.011	
RNA-only	1312	0.949	0.772	0.000	127.557	68.141	
both low	4833	0.137	0.115	33.896	443.296	82.907	

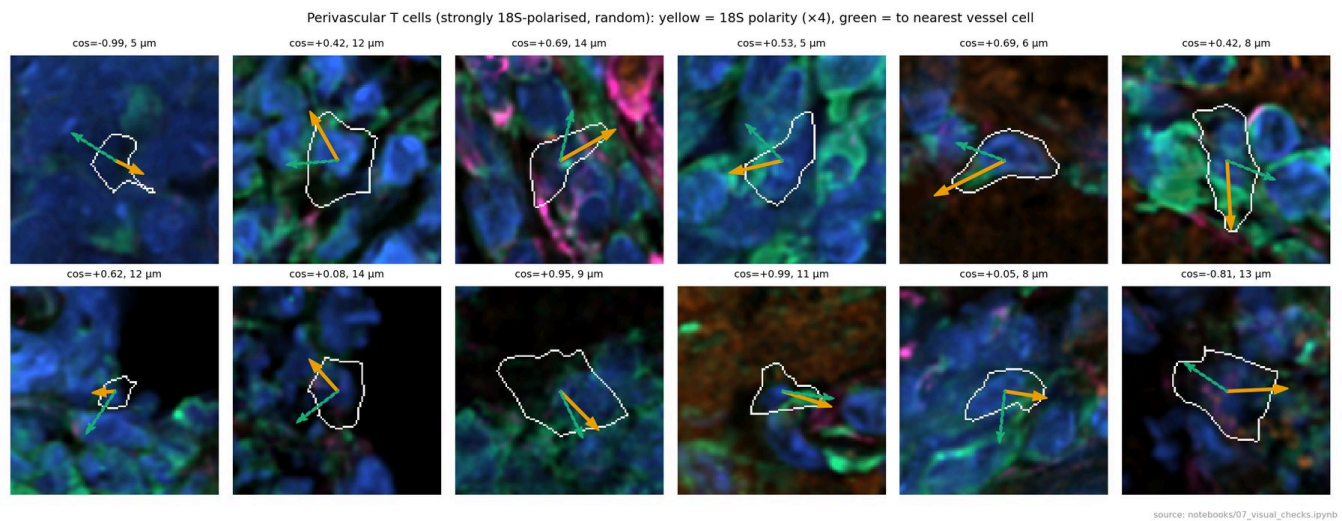


results/07_visual_checks/astro_protein_only_vsmc_gallery.png

Leukocyte polarity: 18S points towards vessels in T cells (not in neurons/oligos); DAPI/ α SMA "polarity" is bleed

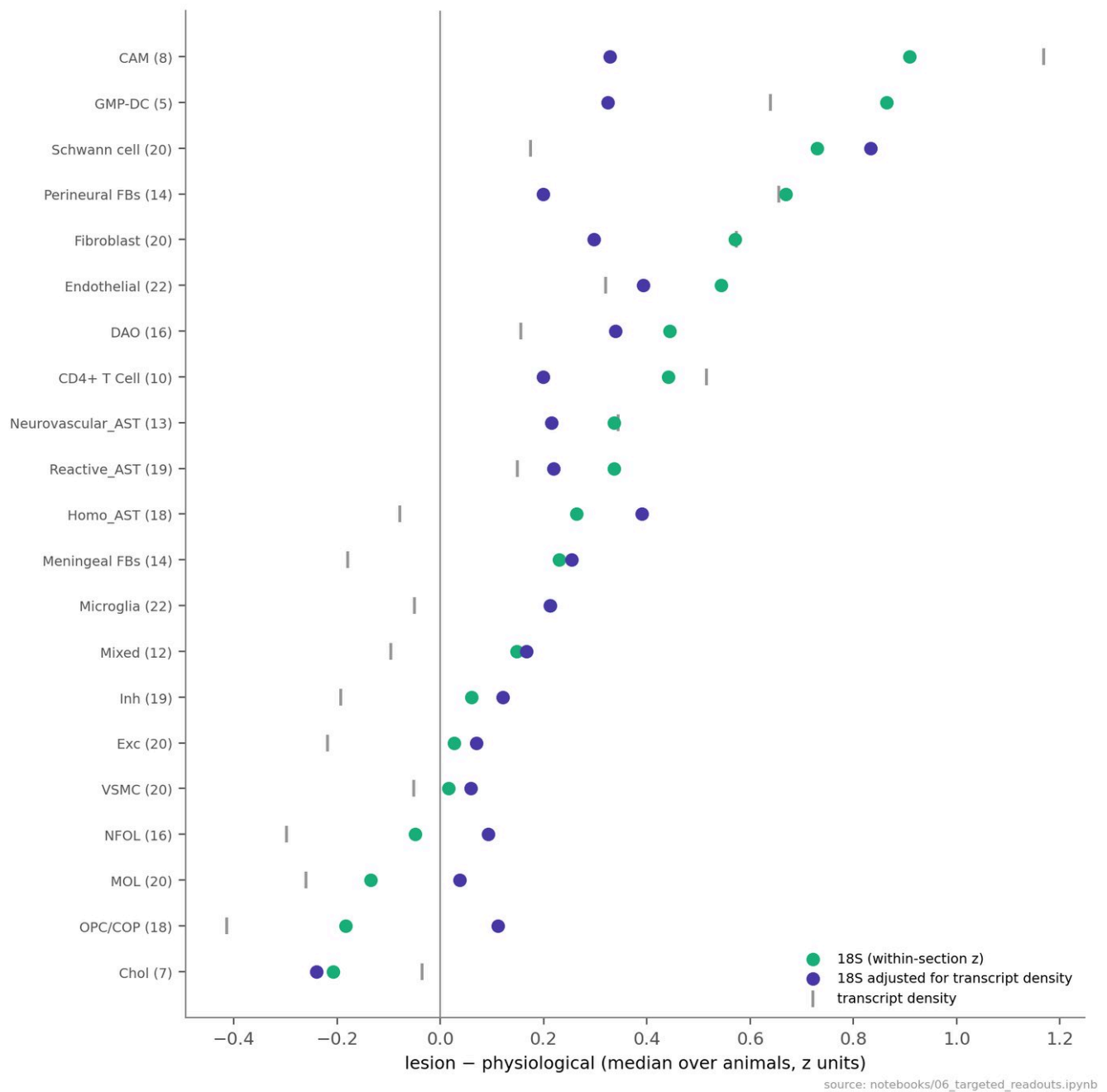


results/06_targeted_readouts/polarity_vessel_direction.png



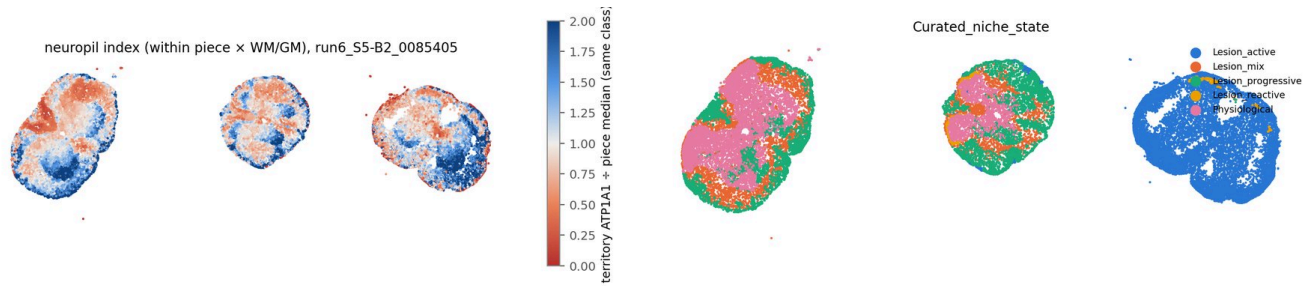
results/07_visual_checks/tcell_perivascular_polarity.png

18S rises in activated cells in lesions, beyond RNA content



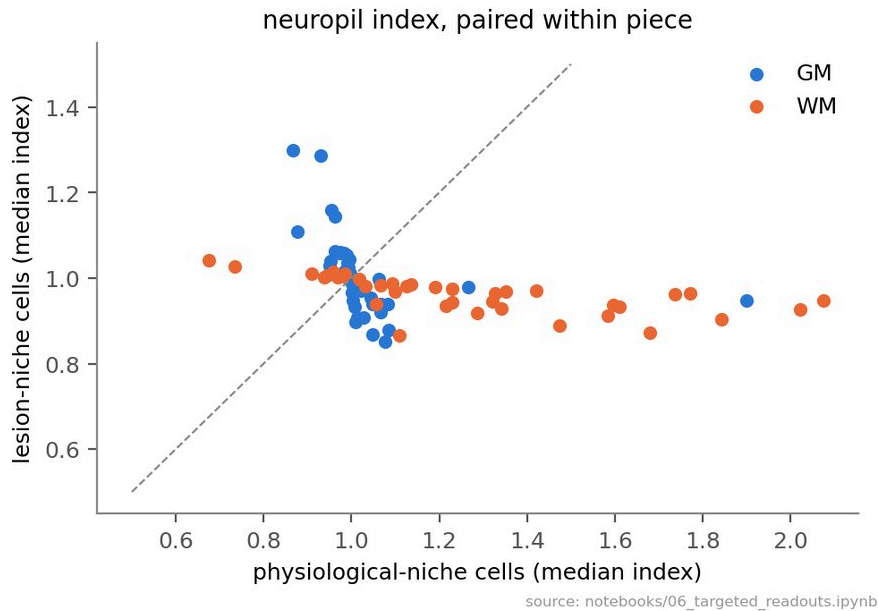
results/06_targeted_readouts/r18s_lesion_by_type.png

Neuropil loss: –25 % surrounding ATP1A1 in white-matter lesions (within piece)



source: notebooks/06_targeted_readouts.ipynb

results/06_targeted_readouts/neuropil_index_map.png



results/06_targeted_readouts/neuropil_index_paired.png

Caveats

- CD45 component undetectable → no immune-membrane readout from ch1.
- αSMA and vimentin share a channel; 18S drew ~95 % of masks (18S distribution features partly by construction).
- Lesion niches are transcriptome-defined, favouring the transcriptome in lesion comparisons.
- 25 animals; only 2 CFA control pieces in runs 5/6; runs 1–3 have no accessible raw images.

Next steps

1. Validate the 18S-texture severity marker on runs 1–3 (raw images on the P drive) or a new run.
2. Disentangle vimentin vs αSMA in "protein-only" astrocytes (VSMC proximity, notebook 07; ideally separate channels).
3. Perivascular T-cell 18S polarity: relate to cuff position / migration state.
4. Use the neuropil-loss index and 18S per cell as covariates in the RRMAPP2 lesion analyses.

